# SOFA TO SINGLETRACK: COACHING PLANS FOR SIGN-OFF

Draft for Kevin, 15 October 2026. Nothing here is in the app yet.

## WHAT THIS IS

The app currently has one 12-week plan for everyone. Three problems came out of the review on 14 October:

1. **Riders who choose two days a week never get the middle session**, so they never do braking practice, fuelling practice, start practice or the kit check.
2. **The 4-week and 8-week plans are just the first weeks of the 12**, so a rider who picks “race at the end” and 8 weeks never reaches race pace, course skills or the taper.
3. **It is an adult plan.** An eight-year-old racing 900-metre laps gets the same 60-minute ride with hard intervals as a forty-year-old.

This document proposes three plans to fix that. Everything is written to be read by the rider in the app, so the wording matters as much as the structure. Please change anything that is not how you would coach it. The questions at the end are the ones I could not answer for you.

## WHERE THE IDEAS COME FROM

- **Couch to 5K**: a fixed weekly rhythm, a first session anyone can finish, one job per session, a week that repeats when you need it, and a clear graduation moment. Nobody is asked to do anything they have not already nearly done.
- **British Cycling and Bikeability**: skills before speed, in this order: ready position, braking, looking where you want to go, gears, cornering, climbing, descending, small obstacles. A bike check (the M-check) before you ride.
- **MTB east**: time-based not distance, the talk test for effort, walking a hill is allowed, mud is part of it, families ride together, and a race is optional and never the point.

## EFFORT: THE TALK TEST

Every session uses the same three words. They go in the app in place of the current “Easy, Moderate, Hard” dots.

| IN THE APP | WHAT IT FEELS LIKE |
|---|---|
| **Chatting** | You could talk the whole way. Singing is allowed. |
| **Breathing** | Short sentences only. You are working but you could keep this up for a while. |
| **Can't talk** | A few words at most. Only ever for short bursts, and never in the Juniors plan. |

# PLAN A: SOFA TO SINGLETRACK (14 AND OVER)

Twelve weeks, three rides a week. Week 1 is the shortest session anyone will ever be asked to do. Every week has the same shape:

- **Ride A, "Skills"** (20 to 30 minutes): one skill, practised somewhere safe. A car park, a playing field, a quiet path. The "done when" line tells the rider when they have it.
- **Ride B, "Steady"** (20 to 35 minutes): the ride that builds the habit. Mostly Chatting. From week 6 this is where the short hard efforts live.
- **Ride C, "The long one"** (30 to 60 minutes): the weekend ride, on trails as soon as they are ready. Always finishes with the "done when" for the week.

The skills ladder across the twelve weeks: ready position and looking ahead; braking; gears; cornering; climbing; descending; small obstacles and line choice; riding at effort; fuelling; starts; a real course; rest.

## The twelve weeks

**Week 1: Off the sofa.** Get on, ride, get off, smile.

- A, Skills, 20 min, Chatting. Ready position: stand on the pedals, level cranks, elbows bent, eyes up. Ride a flat path and every two minutes stand up for ten pedal strokes. *Done when: you can stand and coast for a count of five without wobbling.*
- B, Steady, 20 min, Chatting. Flat path. Practise looking 20 metres ahead, not at your front wheel. *Done when: 20 minutes without stopping.*
- C, The long one, 30 min, Chatting. Flat or gentle, two or three stops to drink. *Done when: you got back and your legs feel fine.*

**Week 2: Stopping.** Brakes are for confidence, not emergencies.

- A, Skills, 25 min, Chatting. Braking. Mark a line on a path with a stick. From walking pace, stop with your front wheel on the line, eight times, using both brakes, no skid. Then from a bit faster. Front brake does most of the work; bum goes back as you squeeze. *Done when: eight clean stops on the line from Breathing pace.*
- B, Steady, 25 min, Chatting. Flat path, ten practice stops spread through the ride. *Done when: you stop without thinking about which lever.*
- C, The long one, 35 min, Chatting. First ride on a wide, easy trail (a green or blue grade, or a bridleway). *Done when: you rode a trail and it was fine.*

**Week 3: Gears and the first hill.**

- A, Skills, 25 min, Chatting. Gears: change *before* the hill, not on it. Find a short rise. Ride up it five times, each time changing down on the flat before it. Pedal all the way to the top in a gear that spins. *Done when: five rises without the chain crunching.*
- B, Steady, 25 min, Chatting. Easy spin, no hills. *Done when: you enjoyed it.*
- C, The long one, 40 min, Breathing on the climbs. Three short gentle climbs. Walk anything too steep, it still counts. *Done when: you got up at least one of them seated and spinning.*

**Week 4: Cornering.** Look where you want to go. The bike follows your eyes.

- A, Skills, 25 min, Chatting. Two drink bottles ten metres apart on grass. Figure-of-eights round them, outside pedal down, inside knee pointing at the bottle, eyes on the exit. Five laps each way. *Done when: five laps each way without a foot down.*
- B, Steady, 30 min, Chatting. Flat and gentle. *Done when: 30 minutes without stopping.*
- C, The long one, 40 min, Chatting. Easy trail with corners. Pick the smooth line, not the fast one. *Done when: you looked round a corner before you got to it and it worked.*

**Week 5: Rolling terrain.** Roots, ruts and the odd rock, slowly.

- A, Skills, 25 min, Chatting. Small obstacles at walking pace: a root, a kerb edge, a stick. Ready position, heavy feet light hands, let the bike move under you. *Done when: ten roll-overs without stopping pedalling.*
- B, Steady, 35 min, Chatting. Alternate gravel and packed dirt. *Done when: 35 minutes.*
- C, The long one, 45 min, Chatting with Breathing moments. Rolling singletrack, no time pressure. *Done when: the longest ride so far, finished smiling or at least not swearing.*

**Week 6: The long one gets long.** Fuelling practice starts.

- A, Skills, 25 min, Chatting. Descending: heels down, bum back, fingers on the brakes, look to the bottom. Find a grassy slope you would normally walk down. Ride it five times. *Done when: five descents with no skid and no stopping halfway.*
- B, Steady, 35 min, Breathing in the middle 10 minutes. *Done when: you held Breathing pace for ten minutes.*
- C, The long one, 50 min, Chatting. Eat something at 20 minutes and drink every 10. *Done when: you ate on the bike and did not fall off.*

**Week 7: Your first hour.**

- A, Skills, 25 min, Chatting. Climbing standing up: on a short rise, stand for the last ten metres, weight over the pedals, bike rocks a little, that is fine. *Done when: three standing finishes.*
- B, Steady, 35 min, Chatting. *Done when: 35 minutes.*
- C, The long one, 60 min, Chatting. Mixed terrain. First ride over an hour. *Done when: an hour. That is the whole point of this week.*

**Week 8: Repeat week.** Same as week 7. Couch to 5K does this on purpose: the second time is when it feels normal. Riders who found week 7 easy can add five minutes to each ride; the app never adds it for them.

**Week 9: Short, hard, fun.** The first Can't-talk efforts, and they are short.

- A, Skills, 25 min, Chatting. Line choice: on a bumpy stretch, ride it three ways, left, middle, right, and feel which is smoothest. *Done when: you can say which line and why.*
- B, Intervals, 35 min. Five lots of one minute at Can't talk, with two minutes Chatting between each. Then easy home. *Done when: five efforts and the fifth was not much slower than the first.*
- C, The long one, 55 min, Chatting with a Breathing middle 15 minutes. *Done when: 55 minutes.*

**Week 10: Race pace, if you fancy it.** Riders on the "no race" plan do this week at Breathing instead of Can't talk; the ride names stay the same.

- A, Skills, 20 min. Starts: six practice starts from a standstill, pedal already up, three hard pedal strokes then settle. *Done when: six starts without a missed pedal.*
- B, Intervals, 35 min. Five lots of two minutes at Can't talk, two minutes Chatting between. *Done when: five done.*
- C, Race simulation, 50 min. Ride a loop at Breathing all the way, the effort you would hold in a 45-minute race. *Done when: you did not blow up in the first ten minutes.*

**Week 11: The real thing, slowly.**

- A, Skills, 30 min, Chatting. The M-check in the app, then a short ride to test it. *Done when: every point on the M checked and nothing fell off.*
- B, Steady, 30 min, Chatting. *Done when: legs felt fresh.*
- C, Course recon, 40 min, Chatting. Ride a real MTB east course, or the nearest trail that feels like one, at an easy pace. Look for the corners, the climbs and where you would want to be fast. *Done when: you could describe the lap to someone.*

**Week 12: Taper and graduation.**

- A, Easy spin, 20 min, Chatting. *Done when: you wanted to go further and did not.*
- B, Kit check ride, 15 min. Test tyre pressure, brakes and the clothes you will wear. *Done when: nothing rubs, squeaks or leaks.*
- C, Graduation ride. Race plan: race day. No-race plan: a 45-minute trail ride on your own terms, then the app's graduation card. *Done when: you got off the sofa and onto singletrack. That was the deal.*

## Two days a week

The two-day rider gets Ride A's skill folded into Ride C, so the week is "Steady" plus "Skill then ride". Nothing is dropped:

| WEEK | RIDE 1 (STEADY) | RIDE 2 (SKILL THEN RIDE) |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | B as written | A's standing drill for 10 min, then C |
| 2 | B as written | A's braking line for 10 min, then C |
| 3 | B as written | A's five rises, then C |
| 4 | B as written | A's figure-of-eights for 10 min, then C |
| 5 | B as written | A's roll-overs for 10 min, then C |
| 6 | B as written | A's descents for 10 min, then C with the snack |
| 7 and 8 | B as written | A's standing climbs, then the hour |
| 9 | B intervals | A's line choice, then C |
| 10 | B intervals | A's six starts, then race simulation |
| 11 | B as written | M-check, then course recon |
| 12 | Kit check ride | Graduation ride |

### The 4-week Taster

Not weeks 1 to 4 of the above. A taster with its own ending: weeks 1 and 2 as written, then week 3 of the taster is week 4 above (cornering, with the first real trail), and week 4 is a **graduation week**: Ride A is the M-check, Ride B is a 30-minute easy spin, Ride C is a 40-minute trail ride and the graduation card. The card says the obvious next step is the 8-week plan starting at week 5.

### The 8-week plan

Weeks 1 to 4 as written, then: week 5 = week 6 above (descending, first snack on the bike), week 6 = week 7 (the hour), week 7 = week 9 (first short efforts) for the no-race plan or week 10 (starts, race simulation) for the race plan, week 8 = week 12 (taper, graduation or race day). The rider who finishes this and wants more is offered the full plan's weeks 8 to 11.

### Race in less than 4 weeks: "Race ready"

If the race the rider picks is under four weeks away, the app should not build a plan that cannot finish. It offers a 2- or 3-week "Race ready" block instead: week 11 (M-check, steady, course recon), then week 12 (taper), with week 10's six practice starts added to the first week. The app says plainly that this gets them to the start line in one piece, not fit, and that the full plan starts after the race.

## PLAN B: SOFA TO SINGLETRACK JUNIORS (ABOUT 6 TO 12, WITH A GROWN-UP)

Eight weeks, two sessions a week, 15 to 35 minutes, every session is a game. The grown-up rides or walks alongside, within sight the whole time, on paths and grass with no roads. Helmet on before the

bike moves. The child never does a Can't-talk effort: Juniors is Chatting and Breathing only, and a race at the end is a fun race.

MTB east's round badges are a badger and a squirrel, so the Juniors plan has two helpers. **The Badger** does the steady, careful things: stopping, balancing, looking ahead. **The Squirrel** does the quick, bouncy things: sprints, bunny hops, corners. Each session is one of theirs. A session is "done" when the grown-up ticks it in the app, and the child collects the badge.

Each session in the app shows: the game, where to play it, what the child does, what the grown-up does, and the badge.

**Week 1: Badger Basics.**

- Session 1, "Badger stands up", 15 min, park path. Game: every time the grown-up says "badger!", stand on the pedals and coast for a count of three. Grown-up: counts out loud, says it about ten times. Badge: Standing Badger. *Done when: three clean "badgers" in a row.*
- Session 2, "Look where the squirrel went", 15 min, field. Game: the grown-up points at a tree; the child rides to it looking at the tree, not the front wheel. Five trees. Badge: Tree Spotter. *Done when: five trees, no wobble.*

**Week 2: The Marshal's Whistle.** Stopping is a game, not a panic.

- Session 1, "Whistle stops", 20 min, flat path. Game: ride along; on the whistle (or "STOP!"), stop as neatly as you can with both brakes. Ten whistles. Grown-up: starts gentle, gets sneakier. Badge: Marshal's Whistle. *Done when: ten stops, no skids, no foot-down-before-stopping.*
- Session 2, "Puddle Pilot", 20 min, somewhere with puddles (a dry day works too: a chalk circle). Game: ride through every puddle without swerving, eyes on the far side. Grown-up: counts puddles, accepts splashing. Badge: Puddle Pilot. *Done when: ten puddles, straight through.*

**Week 3: Squirrel Sprints.** Short, fast, lots of rest.

- Session 1, "Squirrel sprints", 20 min, field. Game: from the grown-up's "nuts!" sprint to the next tree, then roll back slowly. Six sprints, long rests. Badge: Squirrel Sprinter. *Done when: six sprints and still laughing.*
- Session 2, "Gear for the hill", 20 min, a path with a tiny slope. Game: before the slope, change to an easy gear and say "easy!"; ride up spinning. Five times. Grown-up: checks the gear change happened before the slope. Badge: Gear Changer. *Done when: five "easy!" climbs with no stopping.*

**Week 4: Cornering with the cones.**

- Session 1, "Bottle slalom", 25 min, grass. Game: four drink bottles in a line, two bike-lengths apart; weave through, outside pedal down, look at the next bottle. Five runs each direction. Badge: Slalom Squirrel. *Done when: five clean runs each way.*
- Session 2, "Follow the leader", 25 min, easy trail or wide path. Game: the grown-up (or an older sibling) rides in front and picks the line; the child copies the exact line. Swap halfway. Badge: Line Follower. *Done when: you rode a real trail following a line.*

**Week 5: Bumps and roots.**

- Session 1, “Stick jumps”, 25 min, grass. Game: lay a stick on the ground; ride over it standing up, heavy feet, light hands. Then two sticks. Then a bigger stick. Badge: Stick Jumper. *Done when: ten stick roll-overs without sitting down.*
- Session 2, “Badger’s bumpy trail”, 30 min, easy singletrack. Game: count the roots you rode over standing up. Grown-up: counts too; the higher number wins. Badge: Root Counter. *Done when: 30 minutes on a real trail.*

**Week 6: Up and down.**

- Session 1, “Slope slider”, 25 min, a grassy slope. Game: ride down the slope with heels down and bum back, “like a badger sitting down”. Five times. Then ride up it spinning. Badge: Slope Slider. *Done when: five downs with no skid and one up without stopping.*
- Session 2, “The snack stop”, 30 min, trail. Game: ride 15 minutes, stop, eat a snack and drink, ride 15 minutes. Badge: Snack Stopper. *Done when: the whole 30, with a snack in the middle.*

**Week 7: Laps.** A lap is what a race is.

- Session 1, “Lap the park”, 30 min, a loop in the park about five minutes round. Game: ride laps, counting them; on each lap do one whistle stop and one standing section. Badge: Lap Counter. *Done when: four laps.*
- Session 2, “Start line”, 25 min, grass. Game: line up, “3, 2, 1, go!”, three hard pedal strokes then settle into Breathing. Six starts. Badge: Starter. *Done when: six starts with the pedal up and ready.*

**Week 8: Graduation.**

- Session 1, “M-check with a grown-up”, 20 min. The M-check from the app, child does the pointing, grown-up does the squeezing. Then a short ride. Badge: Bike Checker. *Done when: the M is done and the bike is happy.*
- Session 2, “Graduation lap”, 20 to 35 min. A real MTB east kids’ course (U7 is about 400 m a lap, U9 about 900 m, U12 just over a kilometre) or the park loop. Ride the laps a race would, Chatting and Breathing only. Badge: Sofa to Singletrack Junior. *Done when: you did it, and the grown-up has a photo.*

The graduation card says a fun race is next if they want it, with the next round’s date from the website, and that the whole plan can be done again at the next age up.

## What the app needs to change for Juniors

- A plan type chosen when a rider is added: “Junior (6 to 12, rides with a grown-up)” or “14 and over”. Under-14s only get Juniors. Ages 12 to 14 are the grown-up’s call.
- The session card shows the game, the grown-up’s job and the badge, and the “done” tick says “ticked by a grown-up”.
- Timer defaults of 15 to 35 minutes, and no countdown beep on a Junior session: on a 15-minute ride it sounds like a telling-off. The voice cues stay.
- Donation and “Contact a coach” tiles are hidden on a Junior rider’s dashboard; they stay on the account holder’s.
- Coach messages for Juniors are written to the grown-up, not the child.

## QUESTIONS FOR KEVIN

1. The talk test wording: Chatting, Breathing, Can't talk. Keep, or your own words?
2. The skills order: ready position, braking, gears, cornering, obstacles, descending, standing climbs, line choice, starts. Would you move anything?
3. The braking drill: "front brake does most of the work, bum back". Is that how you teach complete beginners, or do you start rear-only?
4. Week 8 as a repeat week: yes or no? Couch to 5K does it; some coaches hate it.
5. First Can't-talk effort in week 9 of 12. Too early, too late?
6. Juniors: two sessions a week, 15 to 35 minutes, ages 6 to 12. Right numbers? Should U7s have their own shorter version?
7. Juniors graduation: a lap of a real course, or the fun race at the Festival?
8. Anything in the Juniors games you would not do with a group of eight-year-olds in a field.
9. The current coach messages in the app (welcome, check-in replies, race week) are still the draft placeholders. Would you like them in a document to edit, or shall I rewrite them in this voice for you to approve?
10. Names: "Sofa to Singletrack Juniors", "The Badger" and "The Squirrel". Keep, or do the round badges have names already?

## WHAT HAPPENS AFTER SIGN-OFF

Once you have marked this up, the app gets: the talk-test effort scale; the three adult plan lengths with their own endings; the two-day version; the Race ready block; the Juniors plan with games, badges and the grown-up's tick; and the Junior dashboard rules above. Each session's "done when" becomes the line the rider sees before they tap "Log this session". I will build it in the app's data shape so the words you approve are the words riders read, nothing paraphrased.